ASAMBHAUUU

Director: Parth Trivedi

Parth displays his fondness for animals in this Gujarati film where a deceased dog requests Yamraj to grant his last wish, which is to be the best man at his pet parent's wedding. He returns, albeit in a human body, to help his 'brother' and avenge his own death

'Aww...' every now and then. And it's not the only Indian film in 2026 on human-animal bonds. Before *OMD*, there was *Max, Min and Meowzaki* in late July, which featured a cat who shakes things up in the life of its heartbroken hero before healing him. In September, Gujarati film *Asambhauuu* focused on the brotherly bond between a man and his dog. Its director, Parth Trivedi, mostly worked with breed dogs—barring one indie stray—which does a noble act in the climax. On October 23, Sachin Pilgaonkar joined the doggo film universe with *Kaapuskonda*, a Marathi film that shows him as a man who transforms from a dog-hater to a dog-lover. Besides the surge of narratives set around pet dogs, the canines have a lesser but eyecatching presence in new films like *Nayyi Naveli* (2026), where a fluffy white dog is a loved family member.

PAW-SITIVE VIBE

For Trivedi, *Asambhauu* emerged from the need to document a social fact: people treating pets as family members. "It is no longer limited to metros or a certain socio-economic strata," he says. "With increasingly stressful lifestyle, there's an urge to find a selfless, loving companion, so the adoption of cats and dogs has grown." Trivedi's film contemporises the famous Mahabharata episode in which Yudhishthira refuses to heed lord Indra's diktat to abandon a stray dog, his loyal companion on an arduous journey, outside the gates of heaven. "My film looks at how far a dog would go for his loyalty and love for a human, and how far a human too would go for the dog," he adds.

And while cats aren't known to be as affectionate as dogs, it didn't dull filmmaker Padmakumar Narasimhamurthy's love for his late pet. In his film *Max, Min and Meowzaki*, he named the pet cat 'Meowzaki' after the famous Japanese animation auteur Hayao Miyazaki, whose films feature prominent feline characters. Much like the male protagonist Max, Padmakumar was allergic to cats until one afternoon his partner's cat inveigled itself into his affection by putting its head on his lap. He is now familiar about their clever ways. "A cat



OHH MY DOG

Director: Amit Rai

Adopting an indie dog during the COVID-19 pandemic changed both Rai's life and perspective towards strays. They are the heroes of his drama, which depicts their beauty, bravery and unconditional love, and subsequently makes a moving case for 'adopt, don't shop'

"We all are woven in a single thread. It is us humans who created boundaries. Animals are here to show their loyalty and kindness and teach empathy"

